

The Conclusion

“Great is the art of beginning,” said Longfellow, “but greater the art is of ending.” Longfellow was thinking of poetry, but his insight is equally applicable to public speaking. Many a speaker has marred an otherwise fine speech by a long-winded, silly, or antagonistic conclusion. Your closing remarks are your last chance to drive home your ideas. Moreover, your final impression will probably linger in your listeners’ minds. Thus you need to craft your conclusion with as much care as your introduction.

No matter what kind of speech you are giving, the conclusion has two major functions:

SIGNAL THE END OF THE SPEECH

It may seem obvious that you should let your audience know you are going to stop soon. However, you will almost certainly hear speeches in your class in which the speaker concludes so abruptly that you are taken by surprise. Too sudden an ending leaves the audience puzzled and unfulfilled.

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REINFORCE THE CENTRAL IDEA

The second major function of a conclusion is to reinforce the audience’s understanding of, or commitment to, the central idea. There are many ways to do this. Here are the ones you are most likely to use.

Summarize Your Speech

Restating the main points is the easiest way to end a speech. One student used this technique effectively in his persuasive speech about the resurgence of tuberculosis as a worldwide killer:

In conclusion, we have seen how tuberculosis has recently returned as a global health crisis. It is infecting and killing on an unprecedented scale. Especially in third-world countries, TB is decimating those who need the most help.

But there is hope. The World Health Organization and privileged countries like the United States can expand their efforts to treat and prevent TB. We have the money and we have the know-how. Now we just need to come together and put an end to this epidemic.

The value of a summary is that it explicitly restates the central idea and main points one last time. But as we shall see, there are more imaginative and compelling ways to end a speech. They can be used in combination with a summary or, at times, in place of it.

End with a Quotation

A quotation is one of the most common and effective devices to conclude a speech. Here is a fine example, from a speech on volunteering for Big Brothers or Big Sisters:

None of us have the extra time that we’d like. But whatever time you can spare, you’ll be making a world of difference in the life of an underprivileged child. In the words of the poet Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, “Give what you have. To someone, it may be better than you dare to think.”

The closing quotation is particularly good because its urgency is exactly suited to the speech. When you run across a *brief* quotation that so perfectly captures your central idea, keep it in mind as a possible conclusion.

Make a Dramatic Statement

Rather than using a quotation to give your conclusion force and vitality, you may want to devise your own dramatic statement. Some speeches have become famous because of their powerful closing lines. One is Patrick Henry’s legendary “Liberty or Death” oration. It takes its name from the final sentences Henry uttered on March 23, 1775, as he exhorted his audience to resist British tyranny:

Is life so dear, or peace so sweet, as to be purchased at the price of chains and slavery? Forbid it, Almighty God! I know not what course others may take; but as for me, give me liberty, or give me death.

Although your classroom speeches are not likely to become famous, you can still rivet your listeners—as Henry did—with a dramatic concluding statement. What follows is a particularly striking example, from a speech on suicide prevention. Throughout the speech, the student referred to a friend who had tried to commit suicide the previous year. Then, in the conclusion, she said:

My friend is back in school, participating in activities she never did before—and enjoying it. I'm happy and proud to say that she's still fighting for her life and even happier that she failed to kill herself. Otherwise, I wouldn't be here today trying to help you. You see, I am my "friend," and I'm more than glad to say I've made it.

As you can imagine, the audience was stunned. The closing lines brought the speech to a dramatic conclusion. The speaker made it even more effective by pausing just a moment before the last words and by using her voice to give them just the right inflection.

Refer to the Introduction

An excellent way to give your speech psychological unity is to conclude by referring to ideas in the introduction. Here is how one student used the method in her speech about carbon monoxide poisoning:

Introduction It was supposed to be a time of celebration. Five friends had gathered in a south Florida hotel room to celebrate a birthday. Juchen Martial, one of the five, was turning nineteen. But the day after the birthday party, a maid passing by the hotel room glanced through a window and saw five dead bodies. All five friends had been killed.

Their killer was silent, invisible, odorless, and tasteless. Their killer was carbon monoxide. The friends had left their car running in a carport directly beneath their hotel room. Carbon monoxide seeped into the room and took their lives—as it does the lives of 400 people a year in the United States.

In the body of her speech, the student looked in detail at the problem of carbon monoxide poisoning and explained ways to head off the problem. Then, in her closing words, she tied the whole speech together by returning to the story described in her introduction:

Conclusion Remember those five friends I mentioned in the introduction of my speech? Their deaths were tragic and unnecessary. I hope the information I have provided today will help you avoid their fate. By understanding where carbon monoxide comes from, by recognizing the warning signs of carbon monoxide poisoning, and by following the simple preventive steps I've discussed, you can make sure that you don't fall victim to the silent killer.

Summarizing the speech, ending with a quotation, making a dramatic statement, referring to the introduction—all these techniques can be used separately. But you have probably noticed that speakers often combine two or more in their conclusions. Actually, all four techniques can be fused into one—for example, a dramatic quotation that summarizes the central idea while referring to the introduction.

One other concluding technique is making a direct appeal to your audience for action. This technique applies only to a particular type of persuasive speech, however, and will be discussed in Chapter 16. The four methods covered in this chapter are appropriate for all kinds of speeches and occasions.

TIPS FOR THE CONCLUSION

1. As with the introduction, keep an eye out for possible concluding materials as you research and develop the speech.
2. Conclude with a bang, not a whimper. Be creative in devising a conclusion that hits the hearts and minds of your audience. Work on several possible endings, and select the one that seems likely to have the greatest impact.
3. Don't be long-winded. The conclusion will normally make up no more than 5 to 10 percent of your speech.
4. Don't leave anything in your conclusion to chance. Work it out in detail, and give yourself plenty of time to practice delivering it. Many students like to write out the conclusion word for word to guarantee it is just right. If you do this, make sure you can present it smoothly, confidently, and with feeling—without relying on your notes or sounding wooden. Make your last impression as forceful and as favorable as you can.

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	例句
1	conclusion	n. 结尾; 结论	The report's conclusion emphasizes the need for stricter measures to prevent public health crises.
2	reinforce	v. 加强; 巩固	Regular training sessions help reinforce employees' understanding of safety protocols.
3	summarize	v. 总结; 概括	The speaker used three sentences to summarize the key points of his 20-minute speech.
4	resurgence	n. 复苏; 重现	The resurgence of traditional crafts has brought new vitality to rural economies.
5	unprecedented	adj. 前所未有的; 史无前例的	The pandemic caused an unprecedented disruption to global supply chains.
6	decimate	v. 大量毁灭; 严重削弱	Drought has decimated crop yields in the region, leaving many farmers in poverty.
7	know-how	n. 专业知识; 实际技能	Local artisans possess unique know-how that has been passed down for generations.
8	epidemic	n. 流行病; (问题的) 蔓延	The government launched a campaign to control the epidemic of teenage obesity.
9	quotation	n. 引文; 引语	The author began her book with a quotation from a 19th-century philosopher.
10	underprivileged	adj. 贫困的; 社会地位低下的	The charity provides educational resources for underprivileged children in urban slums.
11	dramatic	adj. 戏剧性的; 激动人心的	The company announced a dramatic increase in profits after introducing new products.
12	oration	n. 演说; 演讲 (正式)	The president's oration on national unity was broadcast live to millions of viewers.
13	exhort	v. 劝告; 敦促	The teacher exhorted students to take advantage of every opportunity to practice public speaking.
14	tyranny	n. 暴政; 专横	The documentary exposes the tyranny of the former regime and its

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			impact on citizens.
15	rivet	v. 吸引（注意力）；铆接	The actor's emotional performance riveted the audience for the entire two hours.
16	suicide	n. 自杀；自毁	The school has set up a counseling center to prevent student suicide and promote mental health.
17	inflection	n. 语调变化；弯曲	A slight inflection in the speaker's voice can change the meaning of a sentence entirely.
18	unity	n. 统一；整体性	The design of the building emphasizes unity between modern and traditional styles.
19	seep	v. 渗透；渗漏	Toxic chemicals from the factory seeped into the groundwater, contaminating local wells.
20	preventive	adj. 预防的；防范的	Regular medical check-ups are an important preventive measure against chronic diseases.
21	victim	n. 受害者；牺牲品	The organization offers legal aid to victims of domestic violence.
22	fuse	v. 融合；结合（n. 保险丝）	The film fuses historical facts with fictional stories to create a compelling narrative.
23	appeal	n. 呼吁；恳求（v. 吸引；呼吁）	The charity made an urgent appeal for donations to help people affected by the flood.
24	appropriate	adj. 适当的；合适的	Casual clothing is not appropriate for a formal business meeting.
25	long-winded	adj. 冗长的；啰嗦的	The manager's long-winded explanation made it hard for employees to follow key points.
26	guarantee	v. 保证；担保（n. 保证）	The company guarantees a full refund if customers are not satisfied with the product.
27	wooden	adj. 生硬的；呆板的	The new employee's wooden delivery of the presentation failed to impress the team.
28	abrupt	adj. 突然的；唐突的	The meeting came to an abrupt end when the fire alarm went off.
29	unfulfilled	adj. 未实现的；未满足的	Many people feel unfulfilled in their jobs because they lack opportunities to learn.
30	compel	v. 迫使；激发（兴趣）	The novel's vivid characters and plot compel readers to finish it in one sitting.

Exercise

I Fill in the blanks using the most appropriate words from the vocabulary.

- The speaker used a short video to _____ the audience's memory of the key message before ending the speech.
- To save time, the professor asked students to _____ their research reports in no more than 300 words.
- The team's success in winning three consecutive championships is _____ in the history of the sport.
- The charity launched a(n) _____ for volunteers to help distribute food to people in disaster-stricken areas.
- The lecture came to a(n) _____ end when the power went out, leaving many questions

unanswered.

II Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word.

1. The resurgence of interest in vinyl records has surprised many music industry experts.
A. decline B. return C. disappearance D. change
2. The government has taken dramatic action to reduce air pollution in major cities.
A. mild B. gradual C. exciting D. extreme
3. The teacher exhorted students to prepare well for the upcoming exam.
A. warned B. urged C. allowed D. forbade
4. The long-winded speech made most audience members feel bored and sleepy.
A. concise B. interesting C. lengthy D. clear
5. The company's new policy is appropriate for both new and experienced employees.
A. suitable B. difficult C. unfair D. complex

III Translate the following sentences into English.

1. 写作结尾若能呼应开头的核心观点，不仅能让文章结构更完整，还能让读者对全文主旨留下更深刻的印象。
2. 议论文的结尾可通过提出具体建议或展望未来，将论点从理论延伸到实践，让文章的现实意义更突出。
3. 这位作者在说明文结尾处用一句话概括全文关键数据，既避免了信息冗余，又快速帮读者梳理了核心内容。
4. 为让写作结尾更有感染力，建议适当运用抒情性语言，尤其在散文或记叙文里，能更好地引发读者情感共鸣。
5. 学术写作的结尾需客观指出研究局限，并提出未来研究方向，这能体现研究的严谨性，也为后续探索提供参考。